SAMPLE

Dawah: Calling to Allah

The Best Speech -- The Command, the Method, the Audience, and the Caller's Reward

Aira Aurora

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Introduction

"Who is better in speech than one who calls to Allah and does righteousness and says: indeed I am of the Muslims?" (41:33). The verse asks a superlative question and answers it: the caller holds the speech-class's highest rank -- better than the eloquent who call to themselves, better than the righteous who call to no one, because the caller unites the message and the life.

This book is about that rank and its work: da'wah -- the calling to Allah. The Quran legislates it with unusual completeness: who must call (a community, not a clergy -- 3:104), with what method (16:125's three tools), with what tone (the Firawn instruction of 20:44), to what message (the prophets' unchanging core), with what etiquette (109:6's "to you your religion"), against what obstacles (the caller's fears, answered from the Book), and for what reward (the guiding's wage, priced by the Prophet himself).

The reading runs: the command and the caller's rank (Chapters 1-2), the Prophet's own brief as the model caller (Chapter 3), the method and the tone (Chapters 4-5), the message and the audience (Chapters 6-7), the obstacles and the etiquette (Chapters 8-9), the modern field's opportunities and traps (Chapter 10), the reward (Chapter 11), and the good word's own portrait -- the tree of 14:24 -- as the closing frame (Chapter 12).

A word on scope: the tradition's da'wah-science (the books of usul al-da'wah, the field's techniques) is vast; this book stays on the Quran's own legislation and labels the tradition where it enters. The Book's da'wah is older than the field's vocabulary -- and the caller who masters the Book's chapters holds the field's foundation.

A last word on the book's own ambition: the da'wah is the only Quranic command that turns readers into couriers -- the whole 170-book catalog behind this volume exists, at its final accounting, for the conveying. The chapter that follows on the reward prices the guiding above the red camels (the tradition); the chapters before it hand you the method, the tone, the message, and the audience's every filed face; and the closing chapter plants the good word's own tree (14:24) in the reader's garden -- rooted, branching, fruiting by its Lord's permission, and waiting only for the caller's first sentence.

Chapter 1: The Command -- Call to the Way

"Call to the way of your Lord with wisdom and beautiful preaching, and argue with them in the best manner; indeed your Lord knows best who has strayed from His way, and He knows best the rightly guided" (16:125). The verse is the da'wah's complete charter in one sentence: the work (call), the destination (the way of your Lord -- not the caller's way), the tools (wisdom, beautiful preaching, the best argument -- Chapter 4's study), and the caller's relief at the sentence's end (the guidance belongs to the One "who knows best who has strayed... and the rightly guided" -- the caller calls; the Owner decides).

The relief-clause is the charter's genius: da'wah without 16:125's ending becomes sales -- the caller anxious, pushy, crushed by refusals. Da'wah with the ending is agriculture: the farmer plants, waters, and sleeps -- "and the earth's growth is only with Allah" (the frame of 6:59's ownership; the tradition's farming-image for the caller: the planting is yours, the sprouting is not).

The da'wah-command is addressed to the community, not a profession: "And let there be from you a nation inviting to good, enjoining what is right and forbidding what is wrong; and those are the successful" (3:104). The verse's grammar makes the inviting the ummah's standing office -- a nation whose job-description includes recruitment to the good -- and the tradition's scholars read the verse as the community's third pillar (after faith's establishment and the prayer's maintenance): the ummah exists, in part, to call.

And the ummah's own self-description in the Book is the calling's job-posting: "You are the best nation raised for mankind -- you enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong, and you believe in Allah" (3:110) -- the "raised for mankind" is the ummah's raison d'être: a community raised for others' benefit, with the calling as its first service.

The da'wah is not an innovation of the last Book; it is the prophets' common office: "And We certainly sent into every nation a messenger, saying: Worship Allah and avoid the taghut" (16:36); "And We sent messengers before you; We related to you the story of some, and We did not relate the story of others -- and no messenger may bring a sign except by Allah's permission" (40:78's frame). Every prophet-book in this series is a da'wah-file: Nuh's nine hundred fifty years (29:14), Hud's mountain-call (7:65-69's frame), Salih's "O my people" (the "ya qawmi" that opens nearly every prophet's surah), and the last Prophet's summing of the office: "Say: This is my way; I call to Allah with insight, I and whoever follows me" (12:108 -- Yusuf's surah closing with the da'wah's own creed-verse:

the way, the sight, the following).

The Book defines the call's two parties with legal care: the caller is anyone who has received ("Convey from me, even a single verse" -- the tradition's mandate), and the called is everyone who has not -- with no exception the Book ever draws: the relative ("warn your nearest kin" -- 26:214's frame), the stranger, the enemy (the Firawn instruction, Chapter 5), and the ahistorical too (the screens' millions -- Chapter 10). The command's shape is one sentence: the one who knows calls the one who does not, with the Owner's method, to the Owner's way, for the Owner's account.

The charter does not stand alone; the Book surrounds the calling with supporting commands: "and warn your nearest kin" (26:214 -- the da'wah's first address: the family's circle, the hardest audience and the commanded one); "O you who believe, save yourselves and your families from a Fire" (66:6's frame -- the household's rescue as the believer's own charge); "and let not the people deter you from the remembrance of Allah... " (5:67's frame: "convey what has been revealed to you... and Allah will protect you from the people" -- the conveyance-command with the protection-promise: the caller's security is the Office's own undertaking).

And the command's quietest form, the conduct-command: "and say to my servants that they speak the best" (17:53's frame -- the callers' speech-discipline: the word's quality itself is the da'wah's uniform, and the Book ties the speech to the hearing: the Shaytan's sowing prevented by the best form ("that the Shaytan may sow discord" -- the verse's stated reason: the ugly word is the enemy's seedbed).

The da'wah-commands share one grammar the scholars note: the verbs are addressed, the results are not. Call (16:125), convey (5:67), warn (26:214) -- the human verbs of the office; guide -- the divine verb held by the Owner ("indeed you do not guide whom you love, but Allah guides whom He wills" -- 28:56). The caller who learns the grammar learns the office's peace: the doing is exhaustible and commanded; the outcome is owned and timed -- and the exhaustion without the anxiety is the Book's own work-ethic for the calling.

The da'wah's command-list closes with the reader's own door: the Book's constant self-description as a reminder ("and remind, for indeed the reminding benefits the believers" -- 51:55's frame -- the da'wah's own guarantee-clause: the reminder benefits the believer, and the believer's first reminder is the self) -- the caller's first call is the caller's own heart, and the command's first customer is the mirror: "and warn your nearest kin" (26:214) begins at the caller's own house, and the house's nearest resident is the self. The da'wah, begun honestly, is never the caller's gift to the world only: it is the world's gift back to the caller -- the office that keeps its holder awake.